

Time Poverty

What is it?

People don't like things that take too long.

Time poverty is the *feeling* of not having enough time — even when it's not true.

For example, you might abandon an app sign-up halfway through because it feels time-consuming, even if it only takes 60 seconds.

History

The concept of **Time Poverty** was first discussed in the **1990s** by economists and social psychologists studying modern lifestyles.

Research by **Linder (1970)** and later **Gershuny (2005)** explored how technological progress hasn't given people more free time — instead, it made them feel busier.

In UX, this translates into users perceiving digital experiences as “too slow” even when they're objectively fast.

The Psychology Behind It

Time poverty isn't about actual time — it's about perceived time.

When users feel rushed or distracted, their sense of time stretches.

Even short tasks can *feel* long if the process looks complicated, lacks feedback, or seems uncertain.

This perception triggers stress and impatience, leading users to abandon tasks, skip steps, or leave altogether.

Why It Matters

- Higher bounce or drop-off rates
 - Abandoned forms or checkouts
 - Reduced engagement
 - Poor satisfaction and brand trust
 - Cognitive fatigue and stress
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How to Apply It

- **Streamline flows** – Eg: Minimize steps and use autofill.
 - **Show progress** – Eg: Progress bars, completion counters.
 - **Let users save and return later** – Eg: Resume options.
 - **Reassure through microcopy** – Eg: “Takes less than 2 minutes!”
 - **Break tasks into steps** – Eg: Small, digestible screens.
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Theory in Action

- **LinkedIn** uses segmented onboarding steps that help users track progress and feel in control of their time.
 - **McDonald’s** self-order kiosks break the process into smaller, faster screens — reducing perceived waiting time and improving flow.
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Final Thought

Even people with enough time *feel* time-starved when interfaces waste mental energy.

Good design respects users’ sense of time — it feels fast, effortless, and predictable.

Designing for “time poverty” means removing friction and helping people feel in control of every second.